

Introduction | Romans 1:1

Dave York · Covenant Life Fellowship, Roseburg, OR · October 4, 2026

Series: Romans

Romans 1:1 PRIMARY TEXT	53 min SERMON LENGTH	15 SCRIPTURE REFERENCES	40 SECTIONS WE MAPPED
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THE SERMON IN ONE SENTENCE

The gospel is the power of God for salvation for everyone who believes, and that gospel is the unifying message and mission of the church for all time and all places.

Summary

Dave York launches a series on Romans by framing it as the greatest letter ever written—a manifesto of freedom through Jesus Christ that has sparked reformations and revivals throughout church history. He provides historical context: Paul wrote to a Roman church fractured along Jewish-Gentile lines after Emperor Claudius's edict disrupted the congregation. When Jewish believers returned after five years, ethnic and theological conflict erupted over law, circumcision, and church leadership. Paul's response wasn't to minimize their differences but to take them deeper into the gospel. York argues that Romans addresses this specific conflict through eternal theology: all are guilty before God, all are saved by the same gospel, and all are one family in Christ. The sermon identifies two purposes for Romans—gospel unity and gospel mission—and concludes that when Christians are united by the gospel and mobilized for mission together, their cultural preferences and relational conflicts shrink in light of Christ's glory and the magnitude of the task before them.

YOUR SERMON PAGE

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/CovenantLifeRoseburg/sermons/introduction-romans-1-1-2026-10-04>

THIS WEEK ACROSS THE REGION

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/MidwestNorthwest/10-4-26/>

Eight Sovereign Grace churches, one Sunday: Scripture, themes, and How We Said It.

What We Noticed

Doctrinal loci

- **Soteriology** — The sermon centers on the gospel as God's power for salvation, emphasizing that all stand equally guilty and equally saved by grace alone through faith in Christ.
- **Ecclesiology** — York addresses church unity and mission, showing how the Roman church's ethnic conflict reveals the gospel's power to reconcile believers across cultural divides into one family.
- **Bibliology** — The sermon treats Romans as uniquely authoritative Scripture—the fullest statement of the gospel that opens all other biblical treasures and has sparked reformation throughout history.
- **Pastoral Theology** — York models pastoral strategy by showing how Paul addressed real congregational conflict not through avoidance but by taking believers deeper into gospel theology.

Themes

The gospel as the unifying power of the church

Romans as Scripture's premier gospel manifesto

Gospel mission mobilizes and unites believers

Conflict resolved by going deeper into the gospel

The church's calling across ethnic and cultural divides

Editor notes

- The sermon's rhetorical power rests on marshaling authoritative testimony from Stott, Luther, Calvin, and Wesley to establish Romans' historical track record of transformation before unpacking the letter itself.
- York's contemporary analogy—imagining Oregon expelling non-natives for five years—successfully translates the cultural dislocation of Claudius's edict into terms a 21st-century American congregation can feel.

- The pastoral move in unit 25 is the sermon's hinge: Paul's strategy for conflict was depth rather than avoidance, which becomes a diagnostic for the congregation's own relational struggles.
- The communion transition in units 38-39 effectively connects abstract gospel theology to embodied practice, framing the Lord's Supper as rehearsal, reconciliation, and anticipation.

Writing Prompts

Concepts from each main point you could explore further in your own reading and writing.

1. Why Romans Is the Greatest Letter Ever Written

This article would explore Romans' unique status in Scripture by tracing its historical impact—from Augustine's conversion to Luther's Reformation to Wesley's heart-warming—arguing that God has used this letter more than any other to recover the gospel and spark revival. The piece would balance theological analysis with biographical narrative to show why this particular text has such transformative power.

FROM: UNITS 7, 10, 12—WHERE YORK MARSHALS TESTIMONY FROM CHURCH HISTORY AND MAKES THE BOLD CLAIM ABOUT ROMANS' PREMINENCE

2. The Jew-Gentile Conflict That Produced Romans

Most readers approach Romans as timeless theology divorced from historical situation. This article would reconstruct the ethnic and theological fracture in the Roman church—Claudius's edict, the five-year disruption, the explosive return—to show how Paul's eternal doctrines were strategically deployed to address specific pastoral conflict. Understanding the problem unlocks why Paul structures his answer as he does.

FROM: UNITS 21-24—THE HISTORICAL RECONSTRUCTION OF THE ROMAN CHURCH'S CONFLICT AND HOW THAT CONTEXT SHAPES THE LETTER

3. Going Deeper Into the Gospel Is Paul's Answer to Church Conflict

When churches fracture along ethnic, cultural, or theological lines, the instinct is often to minimize differences or separate. Paul's strategy in Romans was radically different: he took both groups deeper into the gospel until they saw their common standing at the foot of the cross. This article would apply Paul's method to contemporary church conflicts, arguing that relational fog of war often signals we need more gospel, not less theology.

FROM: UNITS 23-25—PAUL'S PASTORAL STRATEGY OF DEPTH RATHER THAN AVOIDANCE AS THE MODEL FOR RESOLVING BELIEVER CONFLICT

4. The Gospel Is the Only Answer to Racial Division

This piece would argue that political programs, diversity training, and cultural sensitivity—however well-intentioned—cannot finally reconcile people across ethnic divides because they cannot address the heart. Only the gospel establishes the common ground necessary for true unity: that all are equally guilty before God, all are saved by the same grace, and all stand together as adopted children. The article would be both theological and practically pastoral.

FROM: UNIT 29—WHERE YORR APPLIES ROMANS' JEW-GENTILE CONFLICT TO CONTEMPORARY RACIAL AND ETHNIC DIVISION

5. Gospel Mission Unites the Church by Turning Us Outward

Churches consumed by internal conflict often lack external mission. This article would explore the counterintuitive truth that gospel mission doesn't follow unity but produces it—by focusing believers on a task bigger than themselves, requiring every member's gifts, and relativizing secondary disputes. When the church is mobilized for the nations, our internal preferences shrink in light of the magnitude of the work before us.

FROM: UNITS 31-32—PAUL'S VISION FOR GOSPEL MISSION AS UNIFYING FORCE THAT REQUIRES EVERY MEMBER AND PUTS CONFLICTS IN PERSPECTIVE

6. When Secondary Issues Eclipse the Gospel

This article would name the specific ways contemporary Christians make secondary matters primary—politics, education philosophy, worship style, even theological convictions that become identity markers rather than held truths. Drawing on Paul's strategy in Romans, the piece would diagnose how secondary issues eclipse the gospel when they become the lens through which we evaluate other believers, and call for gospel-centered perspective that distinguishes center from circumference.

FROM: UNIT 33—THE DIRECT APPLICATION NAMING SPECIFIC SECONDARY ISSUES THAT CAN ECLIPSE THE GOSPEL AND FRACTURE CHURCHES

7. Gospel Mission Begins Where God Has Already Placed You

Many Christians equate mission with overseas service, missing the missional opportunity in their daily spheres. This article would argue that gospel mission begins in the mundane geography of your current life—parenting, workplace, neighborhood—before it extends to unreached peoples. It would provide practical categories for seeing your home, job, and community as missionary contexts, while maintaining the global scope of the Great Commission.

FROM: UNIT 34—APPLICATION OF GOSPEL MISSION TO EVERYDAY CONTEXTS LIKE PARENTING, WORKPLACE, AND NEIGHBORHOOD

8. Every Member Has a Role in Gospel Mission

This piece would challenge the assumption that mission belongs only to those who 'go,' showing from Romans 15 and Paul's strategy that gospel advance requires the whole body—some going, some giving, some praying, some teaching, some evangelizing, some showing mercy. The article would help believers identify their particular role in the church's missionary calling and see how their gifts fit into the corporate mission.

FROM: UNIT 36—CORPORATE MISSION REQUIRING DIFFERENT MEMBERS IN DIFFERENT ROLES, ALL ESSENTIAL TO GOSPEL ADVANCE

Congregation Resources

The same resources published on your sermon page.

Small-Group Discussion

Paul opens Romans by identifying himself as 'a servant of Christ Jesus, called to be an apostle, set apart for the gospel of God' (Romans 1:1). What does it tell us about Paul's self-understanding that he defines his entire identity and calling around the gospel rather than his education, credentials, or position?

↳ How might our sense of identity and purpose shift if we anchored it as firmly to the gospel as Paul did?

ROMANS 1:1

The sermon emphasized that Romans was written to address a specific, painful conflict between Jewish and Gentile believers in Rome. Why do you think Paul's response to their division was not to minimize their differences or paper over them, but instead to take the church deeper into the gospel?

↳ When have you experienced or witnessed a conflict within the church being resolved not by compromise on preferences, but by a renewed focus on what Christ has accomplished?

ROMANS 15

According to Romans 1:1-7, Paul frames the gospel as both a promise announced 'beforehand through his prophets in the holy Scriptures' and a revelation of Jesus Christ 'for the obedience of faith among all the nations.' What does this dual emphasis tell us about the gospel's scope and continuity throughout all of Scripture?

ROMANS 1:1-7

The sermon argues that 'only the gospel can reconcile people across ethnic, racial, and cultural divides by establishing our common standing at the foot of the cross.' What is it about the gospel specifically—rather than shared values, mutual respect, or institutional authority—that has the power to unite believers across such deep differences?

↳ Can you think of a time when the gospel's power to reconcile became more real to you than abstract doctrine?

ROMANS 3

The sermon highlights a fallen condition focus: we naturally 'make secondary issues bigger than the gospel' and 'lose sight of our common identity in Christ and our shared mission.' Where do you see this tendency showing up in your own life or in the church—times when preferences, preferences, or personal convictions eclipse the centrality of Christ?

↳ What would it look like for you to intentionally 'shrink' one of those secondary issues this week by refocusing on the gospel?

The sermon teaches that 'gospel mission unites believers by focusing them outward on a task bigger than themselves' and 'begins where God has already placed you—in your home, workplace, and neighborhood.' Who is one person in your immediate sphere to whom the gospel needs to be proclaimed or embodied this week, and how might pursuing that mission together with your church community reshape how you view your relationships there?

ROMANS 1:17

Daily Readings

This week we trace the arc of Romans' power: from its status as Scripture's fullest gospel statement, through its transformative effect on the soul, to its unifying mission that calls us beyond ourselves.

Monday [Romans 1:17](#)

Paul announces the theme of his letter here: "the gospel... is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes." This single verse contains the theological heartbeat that undergirds all sixteen chapters—the declaration that salvation comes through faith in Christ alone. As we begin this series, we are standing at the entrance to Scripture's greatest treasury, and Romans 1:17 is the key that unlocks it.

Tuesday [Romans 3](#)

In Romans 3, Paul establishes the common ground that divides the Rome church must stand upon: all are guilty before God, Jews and Gentiles alike. By taking his readers to the truth that every mouth is "stopped" and all are "accountable to God," Paul shows that unity cannot come through compromise on differences but only through shared conviction of sin and shared standing at the foot of the cross. This is the pastoral genius of the letter—it heals division not by avoiding hard doctrine but by going deeper into it.

Wednesday [Romans 15](#)

Romans 15 captures Paul's vision of the church mobilized together for gospel mission—the Gentiles ministering to the Jewish saints, the strong bearing with the weak, all working toward the spread of the gospel to the ends of the earth. When believers are united by a mission that exceeds their individual preferences and cultural attachments, their petty conflicts shrink before the magnitude of the task. We see here that unity is not achieved in isolation but in the corporate pursuit of something greater than ourselves.

Thursday [Romans 6-8](#)

These chapters move beyond abstract theology into the lived reality of the Christian life—freedom from sin's power, the indwelling Spirit's work, and the groaning hope of future glory. Paul does not simply explain the gospel; he shows how it reorients the entire trajectory of a believer's life, from bondage to liberation to Christlikeness. This is why Romans has sparked spiritual awakening and personal transformation throughout the church's history—it is a letter meant to change not just how we think but how we live.

Friday [Romans 13:13-14](#)

Paul concludes his doctrinal masterpiece not with abstract exhortation but with concrete calls to put off the works of darkness and put on Christ in our ordinary lives. The gospel's power reaches into the real, daily soil of where God has planted us—our relationships, our choices, our witness in the mundane. As we begin this series, we are reminded that Romans is not merely an intellectual treasure but a living word that transforms how we conduct ourselves in the very contexts where Christ has called us to shine.

Memory Verse

For in it the righteousness of God is revealed from faith for faith, as it is written, 'The righteous shall live by faith.'

— **Romans 1:17**

Romans 1:17 encapsulates the letter's central claim that the gospel is God's power for salvation, revealing the very righteousness of God that addresses humanity's deepest need. This verse serves as the thematic anchor for all that follows in Romans and for Paul's answer to the divided church: the gospel alone unites believers across every divide by establishing their common standing before God through faith in Christ.

Family Conversation

When Differences Don't Matter Most

In our church, we have people from different backgrounds, different neighborhoods, different ideas about lots of things. What do you think is the one thing that's so big and so important that it makes all those differences feel smaller? What brings us together?

WORKS FOR AGES 7+

For parents: This prompt invites your family to think about what holds people together when they're really different from each other. The sermon showed how Paul solved a divided church not by ignoring differences but by pointing everyone to something bigger than themselves.

For Couples

Gospel Unity & Our Marriage

What struck you most about how Paul used the gospel to unite a divided church, and how did that challenge or encourage your own heart?

Where do you sense secondary issues or preferences creating distance between us, and how might refocusing together on our shared gospel mission reshape that friction?

What is one specific way the gospel is calling us to mission together—in our home, workplace, or neighborhood—that we could pray for and pursue as a team this week?

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